

URUBAN DEBATE AND PREJUDICE REDUCTION: THE CONTACT HYPOTHESIS IN ACTION

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Abstract: Urban Debate League (UDL) participation offers a unique opportunity to reduce the prejudice of debaters, teachers, and coaches who interact with this program. The UDL is an extra-curricular activity based on competitive argumentation that targets students from traditionally underserved backgrounds and UDLs operate in 24 cities across the United States. Based on Allport's Contact Hypothesis (1954), we believe that adding traditionally excluded voices into debate may work to reduce the prejudice of all who are involved with the activity. The Contact Hypothesis contends that bringing together different groups of people can effectively reduce prejudice if specific conditions, all of which can be created through UDL programs, are met. Data from focus groups conducted with UDL staff suggests that all four of these conditions are met with UDL programs.

As the Urban Debate League (UDL) nears 25 years of age, it is appropriate to evaluate its trajectory—from the hypothetical assumptions made in its founding to the different kinds of scholarship that have emerged to study the UDL over the years. In addition to providing access to debate to traditionally underserved communities, UDLs were based on the belief that the addition of more voices to the debate community would be good for all and would create meaningful contact

between different people across racial and socioeconomic divisions. Specifically, this paper argues that participation in a UDL creates a situation that is uniquely conducive to the reduction of prejudice. One UDL participant put it best when she said "I have met so many different...people through debate. It has helped me to recognize more of our similarities than differences." The UDL offers a special opportunity to bring different people and different voices together toward a common goal of listening and understanding each other's positions and perspectives. We believe that students, teachers, coaches, and summer debate camp staff all benefit from this increased contact.

Several characteristics make debate an optimal arena in which prejudice reduction can occur. First, many annual debate topics involve arguments about race, justice, socioeconomic status, gender, and sexuality. As such, debaters have the ability to research and learn a great deal about these topics and this education often serves to break down previously existing prejudices. Research has found that both general education as well as specific education about prejudice can serve to decrease prejudice (Samelson, 1945; Pettijohn & Walzer, 2008).

Second, in a UDL, the summer institutes, the tournaments, and the authority figures involved are willing to be involved in a program that exists, in part, to support diversity, tolerance, and prejudice reduction. Authorities in the form of administrators and the overarching UDL organizations (the National Debate Project, the National Association for Urban Debate Leagues, and the Associated Leaders of Urban Debate) promote diversity and prejudice reduction as primary goals of the UDL. New UDL programs often begin with a series of summer institutes which offer opportunities to bring together a population of staff and students who are relatively diverse. This diversity often occurs by encouraging graduates of other UDLs to return and teach future generations of program participants.

Third, a special staff of UDL faculty will often work to train new teachers whose schools will be participating in newly established UDLs. This teacher-training staff is carefully chosen to both teach and serve as role-models for the kind of support the UDL seeks for diversity. New UDL programs are also provided with curriculum materials for teaching new debaters that support these same goals. Training occurs at summer institutes and UDL tournaments and focuses not only on debate technique but also on openness and diversity. Diversity training is designed to build respect for all participants and can include role playing, community building, empowering cultural conversation, and assessing different styles of engaged learning.

Finally, through participation in UDL summer programs, students from different schools and backgrounds come together as a group that works toward the larger goal of understanding both the process of debate and the topic for the upcoming year. Debate topics range from the Environment to Foreign Policy towards Africa to Title IX protection of gender equality. Because the debate topic changes every year, students work in the summer, before the competitive tournament season begins, to learn as much as possible about the new topic area. Summer programs often split into “labs” of 15-20 students, which offer a small group setting for learning; usually on a relatively level playing field as students are grouped based on previous debate experience. Labs often split up who will be responsible for arguments in such a way that students teach each other about their different areas of research; this ensures that each member of the lab collaborates with every other member of the lab.

Despite the common wisdom that debate is based on conflict, debate offers real opportunities for cooperation. In particular, at debate workshops, there are reasons to bond and work collaboratively in lab groups for both individual and group success in the short term and over the entire competitive season. While debate is similar to other team sports built on

competition, the unity within the summer lab groups characterizes the lab and becomes a shared identity. In this way, labs become think tanks in which ideas flourish and lab group membership can override many other social groups to which students belong. This cooperation also happens during the competitive tournament season between partners in debate rounds and within debate squads at individual schools. In addition, within any individual round, respect and friendship can build as students learn together from post-round feedback. Because the tournament season lasts a full school year, competitors in one debate round can become friends and supporters on the debate circuit for the rest of that tournament season. Debate can also foster collaborative structures to build the community; for example, in the Atlanta UDL, students vote on awards for the student participants they learned the most from during tournament competition and, as a result, students become eager to teach one another.

Benefits of Urban Debate Leagues

The UDL in Atlanta¹ was founded on the notion that, despite the ruling of the U.S. Supreme Court in *Brown v Board of Education* that all children should receive an equal education, public schools are not equal. Educational disparities² have implications for social and economic well-being, often leading to physical aggression for conflict resolution, gang membership, and high drop-out rates. Educational disparity also furthers the digital divide, which is the reduced access of socio-economically challenged populations to computers in a society increasingly dependent on technology for success (Wade,

¹ Atlanta is widely considered the birthplace of the Urban Debate League in 1985, as a partnership between the Barkley Forum of Emory University and the Atlanta Public Schools. A similar initiative was begun in Detroit around the same time by George Ziegelmüller at Wayne State University.

² For a full review, see Jonathan Kozol's 1991 book *Savage Inequalities: Children in America's Schools*.

1998). The founding of the UDL was also based on the argument that if students could command the attention of decision makers with reasoned words, they would not need to resort to violence to command attention (Wade, 1998).

Because competitive interscholastic debate requires funding for computer access, research materials, travel to tournaments, and training at summer institutes, the primary population that has historically participated in debate can be characterized as fairly affluent and largely white. Committed to changing this demographic and using debate to nurture the potential for all children in the American educational system, the urban debate network ultimately offers an environment for long overdue national conversation across the socio-economic divide.

By 1996, the Open Society Institute partnered with the Barkley Forum of Emory University and began seeding UDLs in other cities based on the Atlanta model (Breger, 1998). Today there are UDLs in various stages of development in 24 cities, and 33,000 students (87% minority, 78% low income) have participated in the initiative from urban school districts who have invested \$11 million to support the programs in 311 high schools and 51 middle schools (National Association for Urban Debate Leagues, 2008).

Debate motivates the development of advanced research and critical thinking skills for tournament participation, and it is a powerful pedagogical tool that can be employed as a curricular class, multi-disciplinary instructional method, co-curricular intramural activity, and extra-curricular competitive initiative. A meta-analysis of critical thinking studies firmly concluded the substantial impact of tournament competition on critical thinking skill development (Allen, Berkowitz, Hunt, & Loudon, 1999). Early anecdotal assessment indicated that gains in grade point averages, reading and literacy, oral communication proficiency, self-esteem, and research skills were strong results of UDL program participation (Ruenzel, 2002). More scholarly assessment

in the academic discipline of communication has begun to document these gains in the last 10 years. Significant changes following UDL participation have been found in self-esteem and empowerment (Open Society Institute, 1999; Warner & Bruschke, 2001), reading and literacy (Collier, 2004; Winkler, 2005; Winkler, 2007; National Debate Project, 2007; Winkler & Holmes, 2007), grade point averages (Mezuk, 2009), and oral communication (Winkler, 2005).

The notion that verbal skills trade off with physical aggression has been documented by decades of academic research. Boone and Montare (1976) concluded that verbal skills can serve as a mechanism to inhibit physical aggression. Infante, Trebling, Shepherd, and Seeds (1984) noted that debate's ability to create argumentative flexibility, rather than verbal aggression, decreases the chance of physical aggression. Fine (Open Society Institute, 1999) found that high school debate gives students greater self-esteem with the result that they "appear to assign higher value to resolving their conflicts through dialogue rather than force (p. 64)." In addition to increasing the desire to resolve conflict verbally, UDL participation has also been found to significantly improve the skills required for successful conflict resolution (Bellon, 2000; Winkler, 2005; Winkler, 2007; National Debate Project, Roland, 2007). There is also evidence to suggest that debate is a real alternative to gang membership (Wade, 1998; Kovener, 2009).

This paper proposes that scholars begin to seriously consider the social impact, in terms of prejudice reduction, of UDL participation. In the long history of psychological study concerning prejudice reduction, there are few programs that create the necessary environment to effectively reduce prejudice. The UDL offers an example of a naturally-occurring program that perfectly demonstrates the conditions that must be met to reduce prejudice.

The Contact Hypothesis

Psychologists have defined prejudice as “an antipathy based upon a faulty and inflexible generalization. It may be felt or expressed. It may be directed toward a group as a whole or toward an individual because he is a member of that group” (Allport, 1954, p. 9). In particular, strategies to reduce race-based prejudice have been of interest in educational settings. One of the most frequently studied methods of prejudice reduction is the Contact Hypothesis, which states that prejudice is caused by unfamiliarity and thus can be reduced with contact that promotes cooperative interaction between two different groups (Allport, 1954). By bringing together groups who hold prejudices about each other, the opportunity to learn about each other should result in less prejudice on the part of both groups. However, bringing different groups together does not always reduce prejudice between the groups.

In fact, the Contact Hypothesis only holds true if four conditions are met. The first condition is that there must be authoritative support that endorses contact (Brown, 1995). This is important because authority can administer rewards to those who help to work towards prejudice reduction and punishment to those who work against prejudice reduction. As such, authority figures are in a unique position to create a social climate that supports both contact and the reduction of prejudice (Brown, 1995). The second necessary condition of the Contact Hypothesis is acquaintance potential (Brown, 1995). That is, members of both groups must be provided with the necessary time to form friendships with one another. Friendships provide opportunities to experience positive feelings toward members of other groups and to learn accurate information about the other group, thus reducing false stereotypes. The third condition that must be met is equal status between both groups (Brown, 1995). To develop mutual respect, groups need to meet on a level playing field. This is particularly true in the context of race because racist beliefs tend to be about the perceived relative inferiority of one racial group; in this case, unequal status can cause negative stereotypes to be

reinforced. The final condition is cooperation to achieve a goal neither group can achieve alone (Brown, 1995). The basis of this condition is the idea that two groups working towards a common goal will have friendlier interactions with one another to achieve their goal. Being friendly, in turn, will lead to the formation of friendships, which will help reduce stereotypes and false beliefs that each group has of the other.

Unfortunately, attempts to reduce prejudice and racism often do not meet these criteria and, thus, fail to reduce prejudice. In fact, some attempts to reduce prejudice have even had the opposite effect and have served to strengthen prejudices. Many authors have argued that school desegregation did not reduce prejudice and inequality to the intended extent (Powell, 2005). If we use school desegregation as an example, it becomes clear that the necessary conditions for contact to reduce prejudice were not met. First, because desegregation was mandated by the court, regions of the country that did not want to desegregate offered little to no institutional support for desegregation, which did not serve to reduce the prejudice of White students. This further led to inequality between groups because authority figures tended to favor White students over African-American students (Brown, 1995), adding to the unequal status of the two groups and reducing the likelihood of intergroup friendships.

Second, unequal status was reinforced by the fact that nonwhite students were often bused to White schools, thus requiring the nonwhite students to adapt to the dominant group (Powell, 2005). Lastly, traditional classrooms rarely implemented cooperative learning between students, thus students of different races were not presented with common goals. The fact that the conditions for an optimal environment to reduce prejudice were not provided helps explain the studies that show that racism increased in some regions of the country following desegregation (Brown, 1995). While desegregation of schools was an attempt to move in the right direction, it is clear this step was not enough to

promote successful intergroup contact. As long as Allport's four conditions are not met, attempts at prejudice reduction through contact are not likely to succeed and hostilities and biases will continue to prevail.

The Contact Hypothesis has been studied by psychologists, sociologists, and educational studies scholars in a variety of situations with many types of people. Research has been conducted in primary schools (Walker & Crogan, 1997; Cameron & Rutland, 2006; Cameron, Rutland, & Brown, 2007; Wright & Bougie, 2007), middle schools (Carlson, Wilson, & Hargrave, 2003), colleges (Stohl, 1985; Tam, Hewstone, Harwood, Voci, & Kenworthy, 2006; Henry & Hardin, 2006; Brown, Brown, Jackson, Sellers, & Manuel, 2003), and after school programs (Rich, Kedem, & Shlesinger, 1995).

Research on the Contact Hypothesis has examined this prejudice-reduction strategy in the context of many different types of groups, including the prejudice of: Whites toward Blacks in the United States (Henry & Hardin, 2006; Brown et al., 2003), Hispanics towards Whites and Blacks in the United States (Carlson et al., 2003), Whites in the United States toward minority-language groups (Wright & Bougie, 2007), Americans toward foreigners in the United States (Stohl, 1985), non-disabled children toward the disabled (Cameron & Rutland, 2006; Cameron et al., 2007), and college students toward the elderly (Tam et al., 2006).

The Contact Hypothesis in Urban Debate Leagues

The effectiveness of contact between groups holds up across different age groups, nationalities, religious groups, and types of prejudice. The difficult part for psychologists has been identifying strategies and programs that meet the conditions necessary for successful contact. Urban Debate Leagues seem to have a unique ability to create the conditions that are required for successful contact between different groups of people. Specifically, we are interested in how intergroup

contact is successfully created for UDL student participants and the teachers and staff that work in UDLs.

Contact for Students

First, during both summer institute participation and year-long tournament participation, authority figures are supportive of diversity and the goal of reducing prejudice. We believe that this institutional endorsement is comprised of the staff that are dedicated to the mission of the UDL and the endorsement of the College or University that hosts UDL summer programs and tournaments. The UDL offers authority figures who are supportive of these goals because the teachers, staff, and schools which choose to participate believe in the mission of providing opportunity to under-served communities. As a result, the UDL offers a self-selected group of those supportive of diversity and prejudice reduction. In addition, as UDL teams begin to participate in local debate circuits, they infuse regional competition with more voices supportive of such diversity.

Second, based on self-reports, UDL participants strongly articulate the belief that they become friends with the people they encounter through summer institute and tournament participation. Debate provides an opportunity to learn from a diverse group of students and also to have informal time at both camp and between debate rounds at tournaments to interact socially. The staff and faculty that work with UDL programs are sensitive to this need and social time is regularly built in to UDL programming. The combination of supportive attitudes on the part of authority figures and a program structure that also supports informal contact across groups seems to work together to produce an environment conducive to successful intergroup contact.

Third, debate lets students meet on an equal playing field. Summer debate institutes sort students into lab groups on the basis of experience. Because summer camps often involve both UDL and non-UDL students, all students meet at an equal level of ability and experience,

which facilitates the students focusing on their similarities, not their differences.

Fourth, UDL participation allows students to work on cooperative goals. Lab groups at summer institutes will often assign students to work on a particular area of research. In order to be prepared, the students must consolidate their individual work. During the tournament season it is common to see students from different schools working together between debate rounds to brainstorm ideas. The students learn quickly that they will be most prepared if they pool their ideas, and winning becomes an incentive to work together.

Contact for Teachers and Staff

Schools are initially selected to be part of a UDL through the interest of teachers and administrators. In addition, authorities, in the form of tournament judges and UDL administrators, are supportive of diversity and are focused on the importance of giving each student a voice, no matter their background.

Second, several types of friendship potential exist for teachers and staff within the UDL. Teachers at new UDL schools often have their own small group lab at summer institutes, so they can become friends, despite their different backgrounds. And, during the subsequent tournament season, there is further opportunity to socialize. Teachers and staff are encouraged to develop mentoring relationships with students through down time built into the schedule, league-wide activities like awards banquets, and the opportunity for extensive post-round discussion. Because of the ways in which friendly, mentoring relationships with students are encouraged, leagues often start to work as one community, resulting in students feeling comfortable talking to teachers and staff from many other schools.

Third, teachers meet on equal footing. Teachers in UDL programs share the experience of secondary school teaching and learn about debate together. They begin by navigating the challenges raised by students and the administration at their schools and work together as

equal participants in the league to help make policy and solve problems that arise.

Finally, teachers often have overarching goals that bring them together. Regardless of their school, they often want to provide opportunities for their students, encourage the success of the UDL, and help students develop critical thinking skills. In addition, as UDL participants begin to attend non-UDL regional debate tournaments, coaches often rely on each other in new settings.

Present Research

On June 21-24, 2009, five focus groups (N = 4, N = 1, N = 5, N = 13, and N = 12, respectively) with a total of 35 participants were held at Emory University. Focus group members were from the Emory National Debate Institute (ENDI) and the Computer Assisted Debate (CAD) Urban Debate League programs, and represented a wide range of staff including college faculty and debate coaches, high school debate coaches and teachers, college debaters, professional administrators, and residence hall staff. Focus groups are a form of interactive research in which a group of people comes together to discuss attitudes about the subject of interest, in this case how involvement in the UDL affects beliefs about, and attitudes toward, people from different backgrounds. Focus groups are a useful form of qualitative research because they stimulate discussion among multiple participants with open-ended questions, and can be used to identify areas for future research. In part, we conducted focus groups to determine whether faculty and staff would identify UDL programs as creating the necessary conditions for successful intergroup contact. We hope that this study will be the first in a line of systematic research into the social benefits of UDL participation.

Before each focus group was held, participants were informed of their rights to leave the focus group at any time and strict confidentiality of their answers. Participants were also told that they would be recorded

and signed a consent form verifying that they had been informed of their rights. After each group met, the researchers explained the goals of the study and gave participants the option of asking any questions about the research.

We examined the focus groups' comments to locate their notions of the four critical conditions for successful intergroup contact: authoritative support, acquaintance potential, equal status, and common, shared goals. The participants affirmed that the four conditions were experienced in the UDL program. One participant summarized:

I've had some UDL experience... and in those situations you realize that there are a lot more similarities between you than there are differences, and the differences that do exist aren't reasons to not get along. They're just differences; things that are unique about people that you can respect regardless of the things that you do disagree with, and the things you don't understand.

Our participants also mentioned the important role that the topic can play in opening up a dialogue about race or personal identity. One member noted that the topic can encourage taking on the perspectives of others and, in turn, can actively change stereotypes:

... [for] students who were introduced to the question of poverty this year, there's an incentive for them to understand the lives of other people who are not like them, and there's an incentive for them to understand what policies work, what policies don't, [and] at what level those policies need to be implemented ... the debate format "complexifies" the discussion in such a way that causes stereotypes to implode upon themselves, and that's the benefit in my mind of debate. We talk about contact with other people and that changes us.

Evidence for Authoritative Support

Staff members who work with students in UDL settings were assumed to support intergroup contact and were encouraged to describe the environment that is created for students at UDL camps. Focus group participants discussed the importance of creating a supportive community as one participant stated:

...the teamwork that we have... [is] more like a community than a team. ... And I really love how we are teaching debate to better ourselves, not to be competitive with one another ... we feel like a big family.

Other focus group members spoke to some of the difference between UDL and non-UDL summer programs, particularly in the UDL focus on academic mentoring and life skills. One participant illustrated this, saying:

...traditional [non-UDL] camps tend to [think] debate is the end goal, whereas, with a lot of the UDL workshops, debate is a means to something much broader than that, to either get the students to see something about their future, in terms of college, or how you can help them make choices;...how you can rethink the situations in your community...

Evidence for Acquaintance Potential

As staff members of debate camps with large populations of UDL students, our focus group participants have spent significant time observing student interactions. Participants spoke of distinctive friendships that occur between students who would not normally have had contact with one another outside of camp. One teacher said:

I have a number of students here who come from a small exclusive private school ... [who are] interacting with the UDL kids like they're best friends... I think that that would have never happened outside of ... debate camp. To see them then interacting with ... UDL kids like they're best friends, and I see some value in the friendship is

absolutely something that would not have happened to them someplace else...

Focus group members represented a wide range of staff including those from residence halls who had contact with students outside the academic classroom. They observed social interactions and friendships that grew in students' free time. One residence hall staff member noted:

... housing staff [at the ENDI] see the kids after [teachers are] done with them... They are socializing when they get back to the dorm and ... when I'm watching them ... kids from completely different backgrounds, not just racially, but socioeconomically, with viewpoint differences, are socializing with each other and not even... talking necessarily about debate stuff, but about other common interest that they find with each other that I don't see always happening in other places in the debate world where they're sticking only to people they know are like them, of their own kind. So, I think it's a unique experience because we have ... UDL students that bring in different insights to the camp... socially, kids are interacting with people that are different from them...

One focus group participant concluded that the UDL experience went beyond debate to real world social applications:

My experience [working in the UDL] has...allowed me to find healthy solutions to conflicts as a result of difference but also just accept people as individuals, you know, who they are regardless of their socially constructed identities.

Evidence for Equal Status

One thing that surprised us during the focus groups was that UDL programming creates more than one type of equality. While UDL camp settings encourage equality across student-student interaction, teacher-

student relationships are unique, in that they are more collaborative than typical teacher-student relationship.

Equal status in student-student relationships. Focus group participants believed that many things created equality in relationships between students. First, having debate learning in common encourages equality. One participant mentioned:

... I know that watching kids ... [who] are getting excited about what they do, the passion is the same. Kids of any background, when they love what they are doing with debate, that excitement for the discussion, for the debate activity, is crossing all of the boundaries.

Second, experience-based student grouping reduces the impact of general education background differences. One participant observed:

It definitely seems like some of [the UDL students] come in, assuming that they're going to be behind the rich kids who have coaches ... I think that over the course of a couple of weeks, ... they start to realize that everyone is kind of on the same level, and that everyone still has a lot to learn about debate. And I think [UDL students] get more confident.

Third, the UDL approach creates equal opportunity for UDL and non-UDL students. One participant said:

... as far as the activity of debate, I have always felt that it was primarily for private schools and that my public school didn't have a chance. And it wasn't until I was part of the urban debate league that I realized that it has a level playing field for kids.

Equal status in teacher-student relationships.

Our focus groups all mentioned the unique nature of the interaction between teachers and students at UDL summer camps and in general UDL programming. One teacher who participated in UDL programming as a

student discussed the larger goal of connecting with students, saying:

...in UDL, it's more, this is what will help you out with your life. ... we've been sharing our experiences with the kids to kind of help them understand that we've been in the same situations that they've been in as far as life experiences and challenges, and things we had to overcome.

Because debate focuses on student engagement and critical thinking, instructors can encourage students to share their voices. One participant noted:

I think that it's very unusual for kids, especially the middle school level, and maybe a little bit more at the high school level, to have an adult and especially a teacher, who talks to them like an equal and .. asks them their opinion. ... they talk about it to each other, ...the idea that a teacher cares who they are. And so ... to a UDL kid that may even [mean] more.

Evidence for Common Goals

Focus group participants also spoke to the importance of debate in creating acceptance of people who are different. One member specifically noted that debate forces students to effectively work together, saying:

Another social benefit is that [debate] teaches cooperation between two people...one of the reasons I'm a big policy debate supporter is that you've got to learn to work with another person for a common goal which schools don't teach kids.

Another participant reported that by coming to a camp focused on a specific activity, all students have at least one common interest that can provide a launching ground for friendships:

I think debate is kind of the one thing they all have in common coming here, which automatically gives them something that they

have a common interest in, which I think is a good starting point ... because they know that they are not really all that different because they all chose to spend two weeks of the summer at debate camp...

We believe these focus groups offer compelling evidence that conditions required for successful intergroup contact are being met at UDL summer programs, and that teachers and staff are intentionally creating an environment that is conducive to successful contact across different groups.

Future Directions for Research on the UDL

We strongly believe that the UDL offers an opportunity to teach students, UDL and non-UDL, critical thinking and research skills while helping them become more comfortable with people different from themselves. Participation in a UDL seems to meet all of Allport's (1954) criteria for creating successful contact between groups, thus making it an appropriate means of reducing prejudice.

Future research on prejudice reduction benefits of UDL participation should focus on testing two different areas. First, examining prejudice reduction benefit for students and teachers after their first experience at a summer debate institute would be helpful in identifying change in beliefs and openness to new people and experiences as a result of an intensive multi-week summer program. Second, examining prejudice reduction for students and teachers after their first season in tournament competition would help determine changes in prejudice as a function of UDL participation.

Because of the social importance of creating equal opportunities and reducing prejudice, the power of the UDL to increase diversity should be further explored. Given the difficulty in creating lasting reductions in prejudice, the UDL offers a promising venue to change prejudiced attitudes. We already know that the UDL offers large-scale academic and disciplinary improvement for its participants, but the time has come

to systematically research the social benefits of participation, particularly those related to the reduction of prejudice and support of diversity.

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